



User Research Plan

US Tax Court Project
November 13-15, 2018

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Our Flexion UX researchers will conduct interviews with participants selected by US Tax Court to inform the user experience design and content required for the Tax Court case management tool. The interviews will help the Flexion UX team understand requirements and expectations.

We will conduct a combination of one-on-one interviews and focus groups onsite. The in-person discussions will explore the current experience, pain points, and ideal experience for users. The interviews include warm-up questions, as well as more probing questions for users of the proposed system.

1 GOALS

Because “usability” can mean different things to different stakeholders, the usability of the product can only be accurately measured when stakeholders agree to a common definition. *Satisfaction*, *relevance*, and *effectiveness* are considered the likely priorities for usability and user goals for the project at this stage of research. These interviews will help ensure that this understanding is correct.

- **Attitude/satisfaction:** Do users enjoy using the tool?
- **Efficiency:** How easy is the tool to use?
- **Relevance:** Does the tool meet users’ real needs?
- **Effectiveness:** Does the tool help users successfully achieve their goals?
- **Accessibility:** Can all potential users similarly manage tasks successfully with the tool?

Further, the interviews should help answer for the team:

- What are the users’ thoughts around the document management process?
- How are users currently navigating the system?
- Are users following defined processes or have they developed workarounds?
- What features and functionality do they find useful?
- What are their pain points? What tasks cause the most frustration?
- What is the ideal experience?

NOTE: BE CAREFUL to not gather information that would violate their non-disclosure agreement with the current vendor...nothing specific about the visual of the system

2 INTERVIEW SET-UP

2.1 Roles

- **Moderators:** Flexion researchers will facilitate interview sessions.
- **Note takers:** Flexion will provide a note taker to capture notes during each session.

2.2 Environment

- Interviews will be conducted on-site in the US Tax Court building.
- Ideally we'll have a private conference room or office to conduct interviews in. (Open library space for a large group. Conference room for 15. Counsel rooms - fit up to 4-5 people, 2 rooms, need speaker phones for remote dial-in)

3 SCHEDULE

- Flexion will interview a mix of roles from those provided by US Tax Court. Based on their usage of the system provided by US Tax Court, Flexion recommends interviewing the roles below:

1. Chambers administrators - 3
2. Docket clerks
3. Intake section clerk (don't interact electronically, all paper)
4. Judge - Jessica will update
5. Law clerks - Y
6. Case services director- Y
7. Petitions clerks - Y
8. Court administrator - Y
9. Assistant deputy counsels - 1
10. Calendar clerk - Y
11. Clerk of the Court - Y
12. Records and reproductions clerk (?) Perhaps a supervisor
13. Trial clerks - Y
14. Practitioner - 2

Future: Employees who work in finance and facilities who don't touch the system at all, we can use the for general taxpayer role

- **Note:** Not all roles will be represented in the first round, Subsequent interviews and discussions will be scheduled for a later date.

- Interviews will be 60 minute sessions conducted on site at the US Tax Court's office in D.C.
- Interviews will be conducted November 13th and November 14th. Sessions will be scheduled during normal business hours.

Tues (10 individuals)

8-9 UX Team setup

9-9:30am - welcome, introduction to ux and research

9:30-11 - focus group

11-12 - 1:1 (track A)

11-12 1:1 (track B)

12-1 lunch

1-2 - 1:1 (track A)

1-2 1:1 (track B)

2-3 - 1:1 (track A)

2-3 1:1 (track B)

3-4 - 1:1 (track A)

3-4 1:1 (track B)

4-5 - 1:1 (track A)

4-5 1:1 (track B)

5-5:30 - team regroup

Wed (14 individuals)

9-10 - 1:1 (track A)

9-10 1:1 (track B)

10-11 - 1:1 (track A)

10-11 1:1 (track B)

11-12 - 1:1 (track A)

11-12 1:1 (track B)

12-1 lunch

1-2 - 1:1 (track A)

1-2 1:1 (track B)

2-3 - 1:1 (track A)

2-3 1:1 (track B)

3-3:30 break

3:30-4:30 - 1:1 (track A)

3:30-4:30 1:1 (track B)

4:30-5:30 - 1:1 (track A)

4:30-5:30 1:1 (track B)

Thurs

9-12 - stakeholder debrief and design studio

4 INTERVIEW PLAN

The following sections outline the high-level background to be provided to participants as well as questions to help guide discussions to achieve user research goals.

4.1 Background Information

Flexion will conduct one-on-one interviews to identify tasks, scenarios, pain points and solutions for the tool. Flexion will also conduct focus groups with a small group of participants of targeted roles. These discussions will provide a deeper understanding of roles, tasks and any overlap or special circumstances related to a role or task. All of these activities are designed to support the ultimate goal of user-centered design.

The project's goals include the following:

- Determine user tasks; primary, secondary and tertiary
- Identify processes; determine what manual processes or tasks could be automated or manual
- Determine workflows and role interactions/dependencies
- Define key application features and functionality for a simplified interface

Our research activities will align with the project objectives by:

- Validating key processes
- Discovering user process pain points and how they are currently addressed
- Discovering features and functionality that works well for users
- Identifying the users' ideal experience

4.2 Approach and Questions

The following approach and questions will be used to frame the discussions with participants. The approach and questions are *not intended to be a script that will be strictly adhered to*, but to provide direction and prompts to elicit users' stories and experiences. Following a brief introduction by the moderator, some general warm-up questions will be asked at the start to establish some background around which to tailor following discussions. Participants will be encouraged to speak freely and the sessions will not be recorded.

Brief introduction

- State the goal and objectives, the purpose for the user interviews: Introduction of the project.
- Give an overview of the interview activities.

Warm-Up Questions

- Tell us about your current role/function at the US Tax Court
- Describe how and when you use the (current system name)
 - Probe: work set-up (Desktop, tablet, laptop, and phone), and other tools, as applicable

Interview Questions

- Tell me about a typical day for you.
 - What time do you start working? From where?
 - What kinds of things do you do? Probe: *Task order, task description*
- Who do you interact with during the course of a work day?
 - What might you need from them?
 - What might they need from you?
 - What questions might you have for them? What issues might you address with them?
 - How do you cover for your colleagues when they are out of the office?
 - How do they interact with you? Probe: *Phone? Email?*
- Thinking about the current system, how do you use that to complete tasks?

- Make sure we avoid discussion of the UI of the current system
- Probe:
 - *How often to you use it?*
 - *Daily? Hourly? A few times a day?*
 - *What tasks do you use the current system to complete?*
- What currently works well for you, as far as current processes and the current system? Why?
- What are your “go to” or favorite features, features you couldn’t do your job without? Why?
- What would be your ideal experience? What suggestions do you have for new features?
- What offline capabilities do you think the system needs to have? Do you need to complete tasks without an internet connection?
- Do you manage permissions and/or assign work to others?
- **Step-by-Step Walkthrough of Primary Task(s)**
 - I know we’ve touched on this, but I’d like to know more about your process. Please walk me through your process of (primary tasks mentioned by the user based on their role).
 - *Probe for other systems the user has to interact with*
 - *Probe for handoff points, where their responsibility for a task ends and another role begins, for example*
 - *Probe for challenges and pain points not mentioned above*
 - What would be your ideal experience? What suggestions do you have for improvement?